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SHARJAH'S FAYA PALAEOLANDSCAPE NOW A WORLD HERITAGE SITE

The Unesco World Heritage Committee has formally inscribed Sharjah's Faya Palaeolandscape onto its prestigious World Heritage List. Located in the emirate's central region, Faya Palaeolandscape has been recognised for its Outstanding Universal Value (OUV) as one of the oldest and most continuous records of early human presence in arid desert environments — spanning more than 200,000 years.

SEE ALSO P4

Dubai's new street project to cut travel times by over 50%

RTA awards Dh633 million contract to upgrade Al Mustaqbal Street

DUBAI
BY ASHFAQ AHMED
Senior Assistant Editor

Dubai's Roads and Transport Authority (RTA) has awarded a contract worth Dh633 million for the development of Al Mustaqbal Street, a major urban corridor running through the heart of the city.

The project, which stretches from Za'abeel Palace Street to Financial Centre Street, is expected to ease traffic congestion and enhance connectivity to key business, residential, and leisure destinations.

Part of a wider infrastructure overhaul that includes the re-

33%

boost in road capacity; peak traffic flow up to 8,800 from 6,600 vehicles per hour

development of the Trade Centre Roundabout, the initiative will boost road capacity by 33 per cent, increasing peak traffic flow from 6,600 to 8,800 vehicles per hour, while slashing travel times from 13 minutes to just 6 minutes. As part of the works, the RTA will construct three tunnels totalling 1,200 metres and a 450 metres bridge:

- A three-lane tunnel heading toward Deira, with a capacity of 4,500 vehicles per hour.
- A two-lane bidirectional

tunnel connecting Deira and Jebel Ali, accommodating 3,000 vehicles per hour.

■ A single-lane tunnel to serve the One Central development, handling 1,500 vehicles per hour.

Additionally, the project involves the widening of Al Mustaqbal Street over a 3.5km stretch, expanding it from three to four lanes in each direction, and the construction of free-flowing ramps at key intersections to improve traffic flow.

Al Mustaqbal Street's development is part of a larger RTA master plan that includes the redevelopment of the Trade Centre Roundabout, a strategic junction connecting Shaikh Zayed Road with five major arterial roads: Shaikh Khalifa Bin Zayed Street, Shaikh Rashid Road, 2nd December Street, Za'abeel Palace Street, and Al Mustaqbal Street.

SEE ALSO P2

Dubai tenants buoyed by new rental trends

SHORT-TERM RENTALS HOT, LONG-TERM COOL AS MORE SUPPLY HITS MARKET

DUBAI
BY JUSTIN VARGHESE
Your Money Editor

After years of rising rents, UAE residents might finally be catching a break.

According to new data from Bayut and dubizzle, the first half of 2025 saw Dubai's rental market enter a phase of much-needed stability — and in some cases, even saw declining prices, especially for high-end properties and select villa types.

With more than 72,000 new homes expected to enter the market this year, tenants now have greater choice and better flexibility, whether they're looking to rent short-term or settle in for the long haul.

Affordable apartments still saw modest increases of around 7 per cent, but some units in Bur Dubai and Deira actually got cheaper — dropping by up to 6.2 per cent. In contrast, luxury apartments in prime areas like Dubai Marina and Downtown Dubai saw only small hikes or even price drops of up to 5 per cent.

Still in demand

When it comes to villas, affordable and mid-tier homes are still in demand, with rents rising up to 9 per cent in popular areas like Damac Hills 2 and Mirdif. But the high-end villa segment tells a more mixed story — some 5-bedroom villas in Dubai Hills Estate saw prices surge by over 50

LONG-TERM LEASES

- Apartments (affordable): Bur Dubai, Arjan
- Apartments (mid-tier): JVC, Business Bay
- Apartments (luxury): Dubai Marina, Downtown Dubai
- Villas (affordable): Damac Hills 2, Mirdif
- Villas (mid-tier): JVC, Al Furjan
- Villas (luxury): Dubai Hills Estate, Damac Hills

per cent, while 4-bedroom luxury homes in several communities saw rents ease by 1–9 per cent.

Dubai's thriving short-term rental scene shows no signs of slowing. Tourists and residents alike continue to flock to daily and monthly rental options, especially in lifestyle-friendly hubs.

Haider Ali Khan, CEO of Bayut and dubizzle said, "Dubai's rental market is starting to stabilise after a period of rapid growth. With more supply and the rent-vs-buy debate heating up, tenants now have more breathing room to explore long-term options."

Bottom line for UAE tenants? If you've been holding off on your next move — now might be the right time to look again. Whether you're upgrading, downsizing, or thinking of finally buying, Dubai's 2025 rental trends are finally offering renters some much-needed control and choice.

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Dubai lets me be rebellious, mum-of-two Miss Universe hopeful says | P15



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Why your chocolates are getting smaller, pricier

World in the midst of severe cocoa crisis

DUBAI
BY JUSTIN VARGHESE
Your Money Editor

Chocolate lovers in the UAE and Saudi Arabia may have noticed their favourite treats are either getting smaller, more expensive, or simply less chocolatey. There's a reason: the world is in the middle of a severe cocoa crisis, and it's hitting both chocolate makers and consumers hard.

According to multiple media reports, a mix of extreme weather, diseased trees, and illegal mining has slashed cocoa harvests in Ivory Coast and Ghana, which together supply nearly 70 per cent of the world's cocoa. Output

is expected to fall by 10 per cent in the 2025/26 season, with Ghana producing just 500,000 metric tons, nearly half of what it did just a few years ago.

Cocoa price rise

This has sent cocoa prices skyrocketing. Future contract prices briefly hit a record \$10,750 per ton in January, and still hover above \$9,400, according to FoodNavigator. That's more than double the average from two years ago.

And it's not just cocoa beans. Prices of cocoa butter — which gives chocolate its creamy mouthfeel — and cocoa powder, responsible for flavour and colour, have also hit all-time highs.



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